



Counterattack kills three U.S. troops

Targeted killing of a foe is often followed by chaos

BY GREG MILLER
AND KAREN DEYOUNG

It took only hours of military strikes on Iran for the United States to find itself in a familiar but unsettling position: the swift removal of a global foe only to confront an aftermath that history suggests will prove difficult to navigate.

The killing of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei marked the latest decapitation or defeat of a bitter U.S. adversary overseas, following the ouster of the Taliban in 2001, the overthrow of Saddam Hussein in Iraq two years later, the breaking of Moammar Gaddafi's grip on power in Libya in 2011 and the capture of Venezuelan leader Nicolás Maduro just two months ago.

The United States has in most cases followed those triumphant moments with varied attempts to fill the void: deploying thousands of troops, spending billions of dollars, backing pro-Western factions and seeking to nurture fledgling democracies. But those efforts have largely yielded disappointment, states that remain riven by conflict and hardly rank as robust U.S. allies.

President Donald Trump appears to be pursuing a starkly different approach with Iran, signaling that he has no intention to use U.S. resources or troops to steer the path of a country whose political fate has been buffeted by U.S. power since Iran's last democratically

SEE IRAN ON A10



MAJID SAEEDI/GETTY IMAGES

Mourners attend a memorial vigil Sunday after Iranian state media confirmed the death of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. Iran's supreme leader was killed after the United States and Israel launched a joint attack on Iran on Saturday. Iran retaliated by firing waves of missiles and drones at Israel and targeting U.S. facilities. The first known American casualties were reported as the conflict quickly escalated.

Iranian diaspora: Across the U.S., Iranian Americans watched attacks with joy, unease. **A3**

Trump doctrine: The president tests a new concept in Iran: Escalate, but don't own. **A7**

Leadership void: Iran faces an uncertain path to find a new supreme leader in time of war. **A9**

By ordering strikes, Trump risks alienating war-weary supporters

BY EMILY DAVIES
AND HANNAH KNOWLES

PALM BEACH, FLA. — President Donald Trump's major attack on Iran has rattled parts of the coalition that twice delivered him the White House, a fracture that could spell trouble for a divided GOP as the midterm elections approach.

The strikes, which killed Iran's supreme leader, followed a visible buildup of U.S. forces in the Middle East. But Trump's decision to carry them out nonetheless surprised some of his supporters, who had expected the self-described anti-interventionist president to stop short of a direct attack.

Nineteen-year-old Cooper Jacks said his phone lit up Saturday with messages from fellow Republicans in "disbelief" at the U.S. attack on Iran — a reaction that reflected not just surprise at Trump's decision, but anxiety

about what a new conflict could demand of younger Americans.

"We often have politicians that are way past the age to be able to fight these wars being all ready to say, yeah, go fight it, and then that burden falls on my generation," said Jacks, an officer with the Walker County Republican Party in Georgia.

For some voters, Trump's decision marked a clear break from the isolationist posture that once defined his political appeal. While the more hawkish wing heralded the opening salvo, others in the party accused Trump of betraying the populist ideology that propelled him to power. In interviews and on social media, many Trump supporters — both prominent conservatives and rank-and-file voters — were careful to withhold final judgment until seeing whether the president could swiftly end the conflict he started. Others reaf-

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HEIDI LEVINE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

First responders carry a body at the scene where nine people were killed after an Iranian missile hit a bomb shelter housed beneath a synagogue in the central Israeli town of Beit Shemesh on Sunday.

Dredging project imperils Florida reef A Texas-size fight among Democrats

BY NICOLÁS RIVERO

FORT LAUDERDALE, FLA. — Dive shop owner Bill Cole leaned back in his captain's chair, raised the volume on the Margaritaville radio station and watched six trails of bubbles trickle up through clear blue water.

Fifteen feet beneath the surface, divers drifted through one of the last thriving coral reefs in Florida, spotting juvenile parrotfish and grunts darting between branches of staghorn coral that survived the catastrophic heat waves and disease outbreaks that have rendered their species all but extinct in the continental

Feds want to expand the shipping channel into Port Everglades

United States.

But soon, this refuge could also be wiped out — not by hot-tub water temperatures or the mysterious plague of stony coral tissue loss disease, but by the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers. Less than a mile away, the corps is planning to deepen and widen the shipping channel leading into Port Everglades, blasting through the reef

line and dredging up sediment that could smother acres of surrounding coral, according to federal scientists.

If approved, "the project would result in the largest impact to coral reefs permitted in U.S. history," Andy Strelcheck, the southeast regional administrator for the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration fisheries division, wrote in a letter to Army Corps officials last year.

A separate analysis from scientists at NOAA and the Shedd Aquarium found that authorizing the project "would constitute the largest impact in U.S. history to

SEE CORAL ON A16

BY TEO ARMUS
AND LIZ GOODWIN

SAN ANTONIO — In the final weeks of the Senate primary race here, Rep. Jasmine Crockett has accused her Democratic opponent, James Talarico, of supporting ads that are "straight up racist" against her.

She has called the questions about her electability in the red state a "dog whistle," aimed at demeaning her as a Black woman and picked up the endorsement of the 2024 Senate Democratic nominee, who blasted Talarico for allegedly privately referring to him as a "mediocre

Race and gender issues are at the forefront of a fierce primary battle

Black man." (Talarico denied criticizing him based on his race, and Talarico has no control over the super PAC airing the ads Crockett objects to.)

As the two face off in the March 3 primary for a crucial U.S. Senate race in Texas, these thorny questions of race and gender have consumed the heated battle between the two Demo-

cratic Party stars.

National Democrats may need Texas — which has remained outside their grasp for decades — to flip blue this year to have a shot at regaining control of the Senate.

But they are eager to avoid debates over identity that have consumed the party in recent elections. Some blamed those debates for their 2024 losses, as voters, particularly Latino voters who drifted rightward, saw the party giving short shrift to economic issues.

The race will test whether Crockett's promise of exciting

SEE TEXAS ON A6

IN THE NEWS

Democrats plot action House Democrats, who hope to regain the majority in November, are already laying out a strategy to investigate the Trump administration next year. **A5**

No-clap flap The Takoma Park mayor's recent no-clapping order at a city council meeting did not earn her plaudits. **C7**

THE NATION **Conservatives** seek to bring the teaching of a "success sequence" to more public schools. **A2**
Trump cast racial progress as largely settled during a Black History Month event. **A4**

THE WORLD **The bones** of St. Francis of Assisi are on public display, in Italy, for the first time. **A12**
Soaring food prices leave many Algerians struggling to afford Ramadan feasts. **A12**

THE ECONOMY **There's a new star** writer at Cleveland's largest newspaper. It's not human, and the paper's staff is upset. **A13**
A new conflict in the Middle East could disrupt oil prices and hit Americans in the pocketbook if it lasts, economists warn. **A13**

STYLE **A historian** is "guerilla teaching" museum visitors about changes to Smithsonian exhibits during the Trump administration. **B1**

SPORTS **A big four** has emerged for the upcoming NCAA women's basketball tournament. **C1**

THE REGION **A school district** went big on electric buses. Now it's ordering more diesels to meet the needs of its students. **C7**

HEALTH & SCIENCE **Deep in Antarctic ice**, a dense network of sensors may help answer basic questions about the universe. **D1**

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